

Grilled Ribeye with Garden Herb Butter

A grilling-session recipe from Jake's Table covering fire control, resting discipline, and compound butter technique. This is the anchor recipe for the Grilling Intensive track and works well as a standalone demo in a 90-minute pop-up format. Jake sources ribeyes from a local East Atlanta butcher - 1.25-inch cuts that can withstand a high-heat sear without overcooking to the center before a crust forms.

Ingredients (serves 4)

Steaks

- 2 bone-in or boneless ribeye steaks, 1.25 inches thick, approximately 12-14 oz each
- Kosher salt - generous
- Coarse black pepper

Garden Herb Butter

- 4 tbsp unsalted butter, room temperature
- 1 tbsp fresh thyme leaves (from garden beds)
- 1 tbsp fresh rosemary, finely minced
- 1 clove garlic, grated on a microplane
- Zest of ½ lemon
- Pinch of flaky salt
- Optional: ½ tsp Dijon mustard for sharpness

Fire Setup

Build a two-zone charcoal fire. Pile lit coals to one side of the kettle - this is the direct sear zone. Leave the other side empty - this is the indirect finish zone. Let coals ash over fully (roughly 15 minutes after lighting) before cooking. A gray ash coat means the fire is at peak heat and the volatile compounds that impart off-flavor have burned off.

Grate preparation matters. Brush the grates with a folded paper towel dipped in oil using long tongs. A clean, oiled grate prevents sticking and produces cleaner grill marks. For gas grills, preheat on high with lid closed for 10 minutes before cleaning and oiling.

Thermometer Reading	Description	Touch Feel	Rest Time
120-125°F	Rare	Very soft	5 min
130-135°F	Medium-Rare	Soft with slight spring	7 min
140-145°F	Medium	Moderate spring	8 min
150-155°F	Medium-Well	Firm	8 min
160°F+	Well-Done	Very firm	5 min

Method

1. **Salt the steaks 40 minutes ahead.** Season both sides and edges generously with kosher salt. Let rest at room temperature on a rack. The salt will initially draw out moisture, which then reabsorbs, carrying flavor into the meat. Do not pat dry - the surface moisture will evaporate during the first seconds on the grate, creating a better crust.
 2. **Season with pepper just before grilling.** Black pepper can turn bitter over long contact with raw meat. Apply coarsely ground pepper immediately before the steak hits the grate.
 3. **Sear over direct heat.** Place steaks over the hot coals. Sear 2 minutes without moving - resist the urge to press or shift. Flip once and sear the other side 2 minutes. For thick steaks, stand them on the fat cap for 1 minute to render and crisp the edge.
 4. **Move to indirect heat.** Shift steaks to the cool side of the grate. Close the lid. Cook to the desired internal temperature using an instant-read thermometer, checking every 2-3 minutes. At 1.25 inches, this typically takes 5-8 additional minutes for medium-rare.
 5. **Rest.** Remove from heat at 5°F below the target temperature - carryover cooking will finish the job. Rest on a warm plate or cutting board loosely covered with foil. Do not wrap tightly; trapped steam softens the crust. Rest for at least 7 minutes.
 6. **Apply the herb butter.** Slice a round of herb butter and lay it on each steak immediately before serving. The residual heat melts the butter across the surface, basting the steak as it rests.
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Garden Herb Butter

Combine softened butter, thyme, rosemary, garlic, lemon zest, and flaky salt in a bowl. Beat with a fork until thoroughly combined. Taste - it should be intensely herby and fragrant. Turn out onto a sheet of parchment paper, roll into a log about 1 inch in diameter, twist the ends, and refrigerate for at least 30 minutes. Slice into rounds as needed. The log keeps refrigerated for two weeks or frozen for three months.

Suggested Sides

Grilled garden scallions: Toss whole scallions from the raised beds in olive oil and salt. Grill over direct heat 2-3 minutes per side until charred and wilted. Finish with lemon juice.

Roasted garlic mashed potatoes: A butter-rich mash balances the richness of the ribeye and gives students a potato technique to practice during the steak's resting time.

Simple tomato and herb salad: Garden cherry tomatoes, torn basil, flaky salt, olive oil. Assembled during the rest period - no cooking required.